

**LISTENING
#15****Teacher's Guide****SCRIPT: STUDENT EXCUSES**

Student: Oh, oh, uh. Oh, Mrs. Smith. Uh, can I take the test now? I just . . . oh.

Mrs. Smith: Excuse me? What do you mean? The test ended 10 minutes ago, and you weren't there to take it. Sorry.

Student: Oh, Mrs. Smith. Come on. Come on. That's not fair.

Mrs. Smith: What do you mean it's not fair? Everyone else was there. Why weren't you in class?

Student: Uh, my bus didn't come this morning on time. That's why.

Mrs. Smith: Um. Are you sure? [*Wha . . . Yeah.*] Your friend, Tony, made it to class, and he [*Oh . . .*] said you were still in bed an hour ago.

Student: Uhh, yeah, well, that might be true, but I really need to take the test.

Mrs. Smith: Wait. Don't you realize you just lied to me?

Student: Uh, we--well, listen. Mrs. Smith. Listen. My alarm didn't go off this morning, so it's not my fault I came late.

Mrs. Smith: You're blaming your alarm clock again? It's still your responsibility to be here. Wasn't that your excuse the last two times you missed class?

Student: But Mrs. Smith, Mrs. Smith.

Mrs. Smith: Listen. You know the policy of our program. If you miss a test for an unexcused reason . . . and a lie is definitely unexcused, then you get a zero on the test. [*Aww . . .*] There are no exceptions.

Student: Mrs. Smith. Why don't you want to help me? You never help me. I mean, I really need to pass this class.

Mrs. Smith: No, no, no. Listen, listen to yourself. You're playing what we call the victim. You made some bad choices, and now you have to accept the consequences. Remember: When you point your finger at someone else, like me in this case, three fingers are pointing back at you.

Student: But Mrs. Smith. I'll lose my scholarship if I do poorly in the class; my parents will be really disappointed in me.

Mrs. Smith: I'm really sorry, but that's not my problem. [*Oh, Mrs. Smith!*] I can't help you with that. Don't try to shift the blame here. [*Mrs. Smith!*] You painted yourself into a corner. You need to be accountable for your own actions instead of trying to weasel out of your responsibility. While you aren't doing well in my class, though, I must say I would almost have to give you an A grade for trying to dodge the outcome of your bad choices.

Student: Mrs. Smith, co . . . Mrs. Smith.

Mrs. Smith: Listen. You are learning one thing.

Student: What?

Mrs. Smith: My name.

Student: Agh.

Answer Key

Audio Comprehension Questions:

1. He says his bus didn't come on time.
2. Tony, his friend, tells her.
3. He says his alarm clock didn't go off.
4. She says it's still his responsibility to be in class and that he used the same excuse before.
5. The student gets a zero on the test and there are no exceptions.
6. b) He is blaming others instead of himself.
7. He says he will lose his scholarship and disappoint his parents.
8. He should take responsibility for his actions and stop blaming others for his mistakes.

Reading Comprehension Questions

1. She missed her test because she forgot her alarm, lost track of time, or got distracted at home.
2. He asked her questions about her morning routine and realized she was not completely honest.
3. He told her that everyone is responsible for their actions, and avoiding responsibility only causes more problems. He also said learning from mistakes is better than avoiding them.

Idioms

“Shift the blame” = to make someone else seem responsible for something you did.

“He tried to shift the blame to his friend when the project wasn't finished.”

“Paint yourself into a corner” = to make a mistake that leaves you with no good options.

“By lying to his teacher, he painted himself into a corner.”

“Weasel out of something” = to try to avoid doing something that you should do.

“He always tries to weasel out of his chores at home.”